

SASHI
REDDI

43, GAMING ARCHITECT
FOUNDER AND CEO, F X L A B S
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 2004 \$5 million
NET WORTH OF COMPANY \$50 million

A PRABHAKAR RAO



SUCCESS MANTRA

Despite a Ph.D, "I am not into theory at all. Daily battles need to be dealt with practically."

major INFLUENCE

IIT Delhi changed his attitude towards education and showed him his future

biggest OBSTACLE

Convincing people about the value of offering niche services

ALL PLAY IS WORK

Aamir Khan's inimitable voice booms even as he jumps, kicks, walks and dances in the desert, all in the search of the arch villain, who gave him the tell-tale scar on his scalp. He is perfect, except that we are not talking about *Ghajini* the movie, but the computer game. "We're glad that Aamir lent his voice and his looks for our game," says Sashi Reddi, the founder of FX Labs that made the game. Setting up the company made the "serial entrepreneur" wonder if "at 43, I am too old to be doing start-ups". Born in Chennai and a product of Lawrence School, Lovedale, Ooty, Reddi focused more on co-curricular activities than studies. But IIT Delhi, where he studied computer science, changed that, after which he went to New York University for a postgraduate degree and completed a Ph.D from Wharton in 1993. He, along with his Wharton roommate Michael Roe and an IIT friend Subinder Khurana, borrowed money and started a content management company called EZ Power Systems. They sold it and he started iCoop in

1999 which was shut down during the dotcom bust in 2000. His third and most successful venture Applabs is the world's largest independent software testing company with over 2,000 employees globally. Reddi stepped down as its CEO to become its chairman.

Interested in gaming, he set up FX Labs in 2004 by investing \$5 million and releasing Archie—the comic character—for the Western world. His first Indian game was Agni with an animated version of actor Malaika Arora Khan as the protagonist. Two years ago he convinced movie mogul Aditya Chopra to promote the sequel to his film *Dhoom* through a game—*Dhoom 2.5 The Game*. It was the same story with Aamir Khan's movie *Ghajini*. Despite his schedule, he does not neglect his family. Till last year he was living in London with his five-year-old son Adith, and wife Ashwini, as she wanted to complete her postgraduate degree. Plans include helping young entrepreneurs with capital and contacts, which are "most important for a start-up." Rightly said. Now play on.

by Swagata Sen

SASHI REDDI
FOUND EARLY ON
THAT IT IS VIABLE
TO MARKET
THOSE GAMES
IN INDIA THAT
HAVE A STRONG
ELEMENT OF
BOLLYWOOD
AND ARE
PRICED LOW.